



Armor on wheels

The first AMX 10 RC (see p.160) was issued to the French Army in 1981. RC stands for “roues-canon,” or wheeled gun, and the aluminum turret carries a 105 mm GIAT main gun—a tank-sized gun in a wheeled vehicle that is not a tank.

WHEELS VERSUS TRACKS

The differences in the abilities of wheeled and tracked vehicles may merge over time, but currently a vehicle must have tracks to be considered a tank. As a general rule, tracks have less ground pressure and can travel over terrain that wheels cannot; however, they tend to be noisier and wear out more quickly. As a result, tracks are usually more expensive. Wheels tend to be

faster than tracks, and have been assessed as appearing less threatening: they are often used for peace enforcement roles ahead of a tracked vehicle. Since scouting and reconnaissance vehicles can be the first to discover mines, the ability of wheeled vehicles to remain mobile after mine strikes make them well suited to these roles. Multiwheeled armored vehicles can lose one or even two wheels and continue to be mobile. A vehicle with a broken track, on the other hand, can be classified as a “mobility kill,” as two tracks are required for the vehicle to move.

At the end of the Gulf War in 1991, French crews parade before their AMX 10 RC wheeled reconnaissance vehicles.